New Masons Evening

Your take-home guide to the first two years

Everything from tonight in one place, written from the questions new Masons and members of the Fleet House Light Blues Club told us they wished someone had answered. Keep it with your Summons. Nothing here touches ritual, and every question is a good question.

Who's who in your corner

- **Your Personal Mentor.** A friend first: the Brother you ring, message or sit next to without feeling a bother. Your first call for any question.
- **Your Lodge Mentor.** Co-ordinates mentoring in your Lodge, makes sure every new member has a Personal Mentor and nobody drifts.
- **The Provincial team.** The Provincial Grand Mentor, his Deputy and the Provincial Mentoring Team. Here to help, never to inspect.

What we mean by mentoring

A culture, not a programme, resting on four principles that run together, all the time. They are not stages.

- **Prepare.** Ready for each stage before it happens. Reduce the surprises.
- **Guide.** Accurate, honest, timely information. Never dependency.
- **Support.** "How can we help?", never "Why aren't you attending?"
- **Enlighten.** Understanding, curiosity and enjoyment, for life.

Family & Connections first, then Masonry. In that order. And Freemasonry must be fun.

The journey ahead, and the aprons you will wear

1	2	3	4	5
Initiation	**Passing**	**Raising**	**Royal Arch**	**Provincial, Past Provincial and Grand Rank**
Entered Apprentice. A plain white apron.	Fellow Craft. Two light blue rosettes. You will answer questions in open Lodge.	Master Mason. Light blue edging and three rosettes.	The 4th ceremony, undertaken within a separate Chapter, which may include members from different Lodges.	Dark blue aprons for those that have been appointed or promoted.

Am I a Freemason before my Third? Yes, from the night of your Initiation. You are a Master Mason once you have taken your Third Degree. Later, dark blue aprons mark Provincial or Grand rank. One Journey, One Organisation: you set the pace, never the calendar.

A meeting night, start to finish

1	2	3	4	5
Arrive	**Get ready**	**The meeting**	**Festive Board**	**Home**
Early. Sign the attendance book. Say hello to the Tyler.	Apron and gloves on. Your mentor will check you are right.	The Director of Ceremonies guides everyone. Follow, do not worry.	Grace, dinner, toasts and Fire, the charity raffle.	After the Tyler's Toast.

- **Opening and closing odes.** Short hymns sung in Lodge. Words vary from Lodge to Lodge, so ask your Secretary or DC for your Lodge's sheet.
- **Signs and the like.** Everyone gets these wrong at first. Practise them at the Lodge of Instruction, not from a leaflet.

- **Bring.** Your regalia case, a plain black Masonic tie, cash or card for the raffle and charity, and your Summons.
- **Do I have to attend?** You should, but it must be fun, never pressure. If you cannot, send apologies to the Secretary.

Three things to do this week

1. **Join the Club.** fhlbc.co.uk/join-us, or scan the code on page 5. Then say hello on the WhatsApp group.
2. **Sign up to Solomon.** solomon.ugle.org.uk. Start the Welcome module that is yours.
3. **Message your mentor.** Tell him one thing from tonight you want to talk about.

What to wear

Always check the Summons first. If it says nothing different, this is the standard. Keep it simple and you cannot go wrong.

Suit, shirt, socks and shoes

- **Suit.** A dark lounge suit, preferably black, can be navy or grey. Black and grey striped morning trousers with a black jacket are acceptable, and are worn by Provincial Officers.
- **Shirt.** A plain white formal shirt, single or double cuff. Some Summons say "white collar and cuffs", which some read as allowing a striped body; traditions vary, and plain white is never wrong.
- **Socks.** Plain black.
- **Shoes.** Black and polished. Not trainers, not boots, and definitely not Crocs.
- **Gloves.** White, where your Lodge wears them. Ask your mentor.

Ties

- **In Hertfordshire.** The Provincial tie is permitted in any Lodge under the Provincial Grand Lodge of Hertfordshire.
- **FHLBC Club tie.** The club tie is permitted in any Lodge under the Provincial Grand Lodge of Hertfordshire, and at other official light blue convocations.
- **Outside Hertfordshire.** A plain black Masonic tie. Keep one in your case: it is right anywhere.
- **Lodge ties.** Some Lodges wear their own, an old school tie in "Old Boys" Lodges for example. No harm in asking at the bar.

Morning dress and black tie

- **Masonic morning dress.** A black jacket (not a tailcoat or long coat) with black and grey striped trousers. Some Lodges keep it for Past Masters, others allow it whenever you like: ask before you buy.
- **Tails.** Only for Active Provincial Officers at Provincial Grand Lodge.
- **Black tie nights.** Dinner jacket, smart dress shirt and black bow tie. Some Lodges dine black tie always, others only at Installation. Some only at Ladies Nights. Some never! The Summons will say.
- **Full Dress or Undress?** For Provincial and Grand Officers only. Undress is a plain dark blue collar and apron; Full Dress adds gold edging and fringe. It does not change what you wear.

Pins, rings, gloves and jewels

- **Lapel pins.** Yes. FHLBC members wear the Club pin; some wear pins of other orders. Typically three. Masonic or charitable, never political: Lodges are apolitical.
- **Rings.** Opinion divides: Past Masters only, anyone, or points facing you until you have been Master. Personal preference.
- **For lodge meetings.** Unless it is hot and the DC or Worshipful Master advises otherwise.
- **Jewels.** Master Masons only, typically no more than three, and only those you are entitled to (a Lodge Centenary jewel only if you were a member that year). From your centre outwards: Royal Arch, Tercentenary, Festival, then Lodge jewels. No other orders' jewels in a Craft Lodge except the Royal Arch. Less is more.

The Festive Board

Etiquette

- Light-hearted and fun, but the Lodge's rules still apply: no religion and no politics.
- Jackets stay on, unless the Master gives permission (sometimes in summer).
- Phones away. A quick photo of your dinner, with permission, fine; a running text conversation, not.
- Urgent call? Excuse yourself and leave the room.
- Stand when the Director of Ceremonies stands; follow the Brother next to you.
- Your mentor will walk you through the toasts and Masonic Fire before your first night. The proposer gives the Fire; if the toast is to you, there is no Fire back.

Replying to a toast

1. Open with "Worshipful Master, Distinguished Brethren, Brethren all".
2. Replying for the visitors? Thank your hosts for the meeting and the Festive Board, and praise the work and the Brother who invited you.
3. Invite them to your next meeting.
4. One to two minutes. Respectful, but no best man's speech. You may step out to be seen; no laps of the room.
5. Mistakes are fine. Every Brother in the room has made one.

The Festive Board, in more depth

From the Fleet House Light Blues Club's Festive Board Lodge of Instruction. Is it formal? Yes, but relaxed. It is an extension of the meeting itself: conversation and laughter, with etiquette and structure.

A typical order of events

1 Brethren take their seats 2 the Master enters 3 Grace 4 dinner 5 wine-taking, usually between first and second course 6 the return of Grace 7 formal toasts 8 responses 9 raffle, if held 10 the Tyler's Toast.

Every Lodge has its own traditions and style.

Common questions

- **Get something wrong?** Do not worry. Observe, follow others, enjoy.
- **When do I stand?** When the DC or Master invites you, when replying to a toast, and for formal toasts when asked. If unsure, follow those around you.
- **Do I need to know the toasts?** No. Watch and follow your neighbours.

The key people

- **The Worshipful Master.** Leads the evening with the gavel. When he gavels, conversation stops at once: the respect is for the office, not the noise.
- **The Director of Ceremonies.** The conductor: announces toasts and keeps the evening flowing.
- **The Stewards.** Likely to be your first office: drinks, the raffle and so on. A great way to put names to faces.
- **The Tyler.** Guards the door, and closes the evening with the Tyler's Toast.

Wine-taking

Not a toast, and never fired. A brief gesture of goodwill between the Master and one or more Brethren, often to thank those who helped in the ceremony.

- The DC announces with whom the Master "would be pleased to take wine".
- If you are named, stand with the Master (unless told otherwise), raise your glass, drink, and sit.
- The Master may first ask the Wardens how they report the glasses: "charged" simply means filled, with wine or water.

Masonic Fire

A traditional salute after formal toasts, which grew from the military gun salutes of the 1700s. Lodges and Provinces do it slightly differently.

- All the formal toasts are fired. A reply to a toast is not, and nor is wine-taking.
- The Master leads the Fire, except at the Tyler's Toast.
- Follow the Master, do not worry if you get it wrong: everyone was new once.

The Hertfordshire toast list

1 The Loyal Toast	"The King, the Craft and Royal Arch Masonry." Given by the Master. No reply.
2 The Grand Master and Grand Officers	All Brethren stand; Grand Officers present stay seated.
3 The Provincial Grand Master	If he is present, he stays seated, all others stand, and he usually replies.
4 Deputy and Assistant PGMs & The Provincial Officers	Not given separately if the PGM is present. May receive a reply.
5 The Worshipful Master	Usually proposed by the Immediate Past Master. The Master replies.
6 The Initiate(s)	Your welcome. Your Proposer should help you prepare a short reply.
7 The Visitors	Proposed by a member; one visitor replies on behalf of all.
8 Absent Brethren	The Nine O'Clock Toast: quiet reflection for those who cannot be there.
9 The Tyler's Toast	The last toast. Given by the Tyler, who also leads its Fire.

Before each formal toast the Master gavels; when it is done, all who are standing sit. The full current toast list is on pglherts.org under Members' Resources.

Replying to the Initiate or Visitors' toast

A traditional opening: *"Worshipful Master, Grand Officers, Brethren all. Thank you for the way that you proposed that toast, and thank you Brethren for the way that you received it."*

- Replying for the visitors: thank the Lodge for its hospitality, mention a highlight or two, and speak for all the visitors present.
- Proposing the visitors' toast: keep it about them, then name the visitor replying (his name, Lodge and number). Give him plenty of notice, not a request at the bar.

Relax, observe, join in, and enjoy. The Brother to your left or right may become a lifelong friend.

The questions everyone asks

From the FHLBC members' list and the Province's own guidance. If your question is not here, ask your mentor: it will not be the first time he has heard it.

Can I visit other Lodges?
Yes, and it is encouraged. You can visit any Lodge under UGLE. Contact the Lodge Secretary and introduce yourself; you may be asked for proof of membership, though you will often have been invited. Visiting abroad? Ask the Provincial Secretary first, as permission may be needed.

What is a Lodge of Instruction?
An informal run-through of the next meeting, so everyone knows the lines and movements. Usually no suit needed. Go even with no office: it is how you learn, and how you get to know the Brethren between meetings. Royal Arch Chapters have Chapters of Instruction.

Taylor's or Emulation?
The two main workings in Hertfordshire. Emulation is the more relaxed; Taylor's has more intricate floorwork, such as squaring the Lodge. Learned Taylor's and asked to work in an Emulation Lodge? Fine. Emulation floorwork in a Taylor's Lodge may be frowned on. If in doubt, ask.

What are the letters after names?
Ranks from the Province or Grand Lodge, Active or Past. The jargon buster decodes them. Nobody minds being asked.

Can I attend Provincial Grand Lodge?
Once you are a Master Mason.

What is a White Table?
Partners are invited to dine, and sometimes into the meeting, which is then not tyled. A lovely way to show them what you do.

What is a Ladies Night?
The Master's formal dinner each year, often with a dance, raising money for his chosen charity. Some Lodges go away for a weekend instead.

What do I tell people at work? Can I post online?
The truth: you have joined a Lodge, you meet a few times a year and it raises a lot for charity. Festive Board and charity photos, fine; anything from inside the Lodge room, not.

What is the Royal Arch?
The Royal Arch completes Pure Antient Masonry and is your fourth ceremony; your Royal Arch Representative will explain it when you are ready.

Operative or speculative?
Operative masons worked stone. We are speculative: we use their tools and principles as lessons for life.

What if I am struggling?
Say so, early, to anyone: your mentor, the Almoner, a Brother, the Club. The question is always "How can we help?"

Bigger than your Lodge

- Your Lodge is your home, not the whole of Freemasonry. Visit Lodges at Masonic centres across the county; go with your mentor or the Club the first time.
- Every Lodge has its own size, pace and character. If yours feels quiet, that is a reason to visit a lively one, not to leave. Ask the Club which First Degrees are coming up to watch.
- Lodges support local causes and the Masonic Charitable Foundation. Your Charity Steward will tell you how your Lodge gives.

Learning ritual without losing sleep

1. Start early: months, not the week before.
2. Little and often: ten minutes a day beats an hour on Sunday.
3. Read it, then read it aloud. Look up any word you do not know.
4. Record it, and play it back on the commute.
5. A line at a time. Build it up; never swallow it whole.
6. Have a Brother hold the book and correct you afterwards.
7. Rehearse in the Lodge room, then at the Lodge of Instruction.
8. Understand it: words you understand stay learned.

Nobody has to learn more than the questions and answers between degrees.

Solomon: UGLE's free learning hub

- solomon.ugle.org.uk: papers, Nuggets, presentations and quizzes, at your own pace. Register with your name, Lodge name and number.
- Four Welcome modules (Apprentice, Fellow Craft, Master Mason, Companion). Score 100% in each quiz for a certificate; all four earn the Diploma and UGLE's Solomon Academy tie pin, presented in Lodge.
- Use the evenings you cannot be in the room to explore with your mentor. And ask to join DAWG, the Daily Advancement WhatsApp Group.

Scan to start

Jargon buster

The words and letters you will hear in your first two years. Nobody minds being asked what anything means, including the letters after their name. Ask.

Words you will hear

Lodge	A group of Freemasons who meet together, with a name and a number. It elects a Master and officers each year.
Province	The Lodges of a county area under a Provincial Grand Master. Above the Province is Grand Lodge.
UGLE	The United Grand Lodge of England, at Freemasons' Hall, London: the governing body.
Summons	The notice of a meeting: date, time, dress and business. Most answers are in it.
Festive Board	The meal after the meeting: toasts, speeches and friendships.
Masonic Fire	The pattern of applause after a toast. Nobody expects you to know it.
Lodge of Instruction	The informal rehearsal, run by the Preceptor.
Installation	The yearly meeting where the new Master is installed. Often black tie.
Initiation, Passing, Raising	The ceremonies that make you an Entered Apprentice, Fellow Craft and Master Mason.
Royal Arch, Chapter	The completion of Pure Antient Masonry. A Chapter is to the Royal Arch what a Lodge is to the Craft.
Almoner	Looks after members' welfare, in confidence.
Charity Steward	Leads your Lodge's charitable giving.
Preceptor	Runs the Lodge of Instruction and coaches the ritual.

Letters you will see

WM, IPM	Worshipful Master; Immediate Past Master.
SW, JW	Senior and Junior Warden, who usually become Master in turn.
SD, JD, IG	Senior and Junior Deacon, Inner Guard: the floor officers.
DC, ADC	Director of Ceremonies and his Assistant. Follow the DC.
EA, FC, MM	Entered Apprentice, Fellow Craft, Master Mason.
PM	Past Master. In mentoring papers, also Personal Mentor.
LM	Lodge Mentor.
ProvGM, AProvGM	Provincial Grand Master; Assistant Provincial Grand Master.
ProvGMen	Provincial Grand Mentor.
VO	Visiting Officer: visits your Lodge for the Province. A friend.
LoI, CoI	Lodge of Instruction; Chapter of Instruction.
PGL, GL	Provincial Grand Lodge; Grand Lodge.
FHLBC	Fleet House Light Blues Club.
DAWG	Daily Advancement WhatsApp Group.
Solomon, Hermes	UGLE's learning platform; its membership system, used by your Secretary.

Decoding ranks on a Summons

P	Past: the rank was held, or awarded as a past rank.
Prov	Provincial, active now in Hertfordshire. PProv: past active.
PP	Past Provincial rank, never active. PPJGW = Past Provincial Junior Grand Warden.
No Prov?	A Grand Lodge rank. PAGDC = Past Assistant Grand Director of Ceremonies.
S, J, A, Dep	Senior, Junior, Assistant, Deputy.
W, D, DC	Warden, Deacon, Director of Ceremonies.
Sec, Reg, Chap	Secretary, Registrar, Chaplain.
SwdB, StB, Purs	Sword Bearer, Standard Bearer, Pursuivant.
LGR	London Grand Rank, from Metropolitan Grand Lodge.
Bro, W Bro	Bro = every Brother; W Bro = one who has been Master or holds rank.
VW Bro, RW Bro	Senior ranks: the Deputy is VW Bro, the Provincial Grand Master RW Bro.

Fleet House Light Blues Club

- Every white or light blue apron in Hertfordshire; EAs welcome. £25 to join, then £10 a year (EAs £10).

Secretary@fhlbc.co.uk

Events: www.fhlbc.co.uk/events

Scan to join

Stay in touch

mentor@hertfordshirefreemasons.org.uk

asstmentor@hertfordshirefreemasons.org.uk

Provincial Office, Fleet House, 10 Parkway, St Albans AL3 6PA · 01727 833061

You are not on this journey alone, and remember: whatever you do, it must be fun!

Notes

Questions to ask your mentor, names to remember, things you want to look up on Solomon.

My people

My Personal Mentor	
My Lodge Mentor	
Lodge Secretary	
Lodge of Instruction: when and where	
My next meeting	

Questions to ask my mentor

Notes